

“And I see that you have a stereo and television. Anything else of any substantial value, like an insurance policy or stocks?”

“No,” Bill replied again, “just the normal junk furniture that most college students accumulate over the years.”

“Bill, I do have a small insurance policy that Daddy bought for me when I was a little girl,” Andrea said.

“Do you know if it has any cash value, Andrea?” Mr. McKenna asked.

“I think so. I had forgotten that I even had it until you mentioned the insurance. Daddy said it would pay either a lump sum or provide enough for burial, but I don’t know how much.”

“Okay, what we have to work with, then, is the potential sale of one car, a stereo, a TV, and some cash in an insurance policy.”

“But we need both of our cars if we’re both going to work,” Andrea argued. “Bill works on the west end of town, and as soon as I finish my student teaching, I’ll probably have a job in another.”

“I know it won’t be easy, but it is possible. You both need to be totally realistic about your situation, and since we don’t have a lot of leeway in time, I’m going to lay it out for you. I hope this doesn’t frighten you, but you need to face reality.

“First, the bank has already started action against Andrea’s mother. In less than two weeks, there will be a court hearing, and I feel sure the judge will grant the petition to attach her property unless we can work out another arrangement in the meantime.

“Second, even without the debts, you’re living beyond your means right now. You can’t afford a second car. It takes extra insurance, maintenance, and gas.

“Third, I assume that the stereo and TV were bought with the credit card, so you need to sell them and return the money to the bank. Obviously you won’t get back what you paid, but that’s the way it is usually.

“Even after you do these things, your budget won’t balance while you’re paying off the remaining debts, unless you both work. That